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CENTRAL ACTS AMENDED

The reform covers 23 ministries and 784 provisions across multiple sectors

WARNING BEFORE PUNISHMENT

Before: First-time slips could get penalties, hurt MSMEs and small operators without compliance capacity

Reform: Warning/ advisory/ improvement notices before penalty for minor or first-time defaults

Now: 63 provisions provide warning or notice for first-time default; business laws use graded enforcement

Examples: Tea Act and APEDA Act: failure to furnish returns follows warning-and-penalty framework instead of immediate punitive action

MSME-FRIENDLY COMPLIANCE

Before: MSMEs faced criminal action for lapses in record-keeping or licence display

Reform: Small firms get chance to rectify lapses; strong penalties for repeated violations

Now: Reduces compliance uncertainty and litigation risk

Example: Legal Metrology Act: first lapse now gets notice

EASE OF LIVING FOR CITIZENS

Before: Citizens could face criminal process for minor infractions in transport, civic or municipal laws

Reform: Convert minor offences into civil penalties or remove them

Now: 67 provisions aimed specifically at improving ease of living

Example: Railways Act: refusal to vacate reserved berth converted to civil penalty of up to Rs 1,000

FAIRER MUNICIPAL LAW

Before: Criminal exposure possible for minor municipal violations or inconsistent civic systems

Reform: Rationalise municipal offences and modernise selected civic provisions

Now: Minor civic violations converted into civil penalties; outdated provisions removed

Example: NDMC Act: illegal public water use has Rs 1,000 civil penalty

MOBILITY AND ACCIDENT RELIEF

Before: One-day licence expiry could make a driver technically non-compliant; accident victims could lose compensation rights due to delays in filing

Reform: Reasonable grace period and extended access to compensation where delay is justified

Now: Expired licence is temporarily valid; accident victims get more time to go to Claims Tribunal

Example: Motor Vehicles Act: 30-day renewal grace period and extended filing window for accident compensation claims

ENDING REGIME OF SUSPICION

Before: Being out or in a building/vehicle at night without satisfactory explanation could lead to jail

Reform: Abolish suspicion-based offence that criminalised ordinary presence without evidence of wrongdoing

Now: No more criminal liability for merely being outdoors at night

Example: Delhi Police Act Section 102(c): offence removed

COURTS AND ENFORCEMENT BURDEN REDUCED

Before: Minor cases could enter criminal justice system

Reform: Adjudicating officers, appellate authorities, civil penalties, compounding to resolve matters faster

Now: Less burden on courts; enforcement remains proportionate

Example: 17 provisions introduce compounding of offences; 17 provisions reduce jail terms

TRUST-BASED GOVERNANCE

Before: Regulatory design often assumed mistrust and treated non-compliance as criminal misconduct

Reform: Create a proportional, dynamic penalty framework that encourages voluntary compliance

Now: More predictable, humane and business-friendly regulatory environment while serious violations still attract penalties

Example: Apprentices Act: procedural non-compliance to follow advisory, warning and then monetary penalty for repeated violations

Source: Press Information Bureau, Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026, dated Apr. 4, 2026